

3150_{BCE} – 30_{CE}

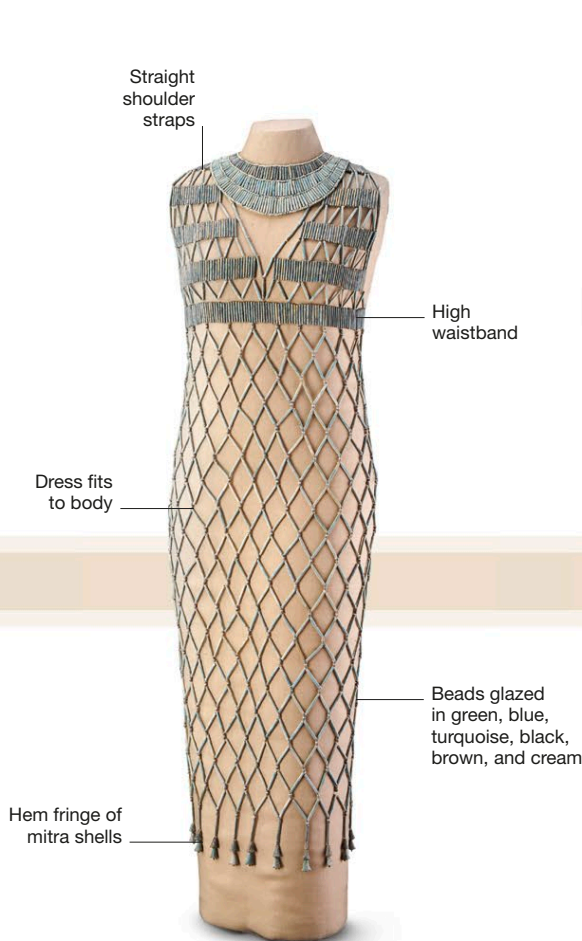
ANCIENT EGYPT

For three thousand years almost all clothing worn by the Ancient Egyptians was of linen, made from flax grown in the Nile Valley. The fabric suited the hot climate because it was cool and airy. Clothes were very simple in shape, with minimal cutting of cloth. Men wore a *schenti* cloth wrapped around the hips which hung in folds in front. Women wore a *kalasiris* (sheath-like dress), often with detachable sleeves. The *mss* (bag-shirt) was worn in the Middle Kingdom and later became general wear for men, women, and children. The silhouette was influenced by two key factors: the fineness and finish of the linen – either left with a natural crimp after laundering, or (in the New Kingdom) arranged in crisp pleats – and by the wearing of decorative collars and belts. These accessories were rich in colour and texture.



Ceremonial dress In this wooden sculpture from Thebes, c.1900_{BCE}, a female bearer wears a beaded dress with a beadwork collar. Typically for Ancient Egyptians, she wears a wig, heavy make-up, and rich jewellery.

Box of offerings for the gods
Kohl accentuates eyes
Indigo-dyed wig
Beaded dress could be made of leather thonging
Bracelets match anklets



Beaded dress This bead-net dress from about 2400_{BCE} is made of 3,000 cylindrical and disc-shaped coloured beads. It is decorated with shells and breast caps. A dancing girl may have worn it for entertaining at banquets.



Queen Nefertari On this fresco in the Valley of the Queens, Thebes, Queen Nefertari wears the finest linen, which is almost transparent. She has an elaborate headdress featuring a gilded figure of a vulture, as well as a gold collar.



Priestly costume This statuette of a priest from the 20th dynasty (c.1187–1064_{BCE}) shows his pleated robe, which may have had fringed ends. There are traces of kohl around his eyes.